cent, while the tiger population surged from 178 in 2006 to 572 in 2022, a rise of nearly 222 per cent. "Uttarakhand has seen a significant rise in the numbers of tigers, elephants and leopards over the years," says Dr Vivek Pandey, additional principal chief conservator of forests (wildlife). But he sees rising wildlife populations as only part of the reason for the frequency of serious encounters. "A large share of our population lives close to forests," he adds.

Nearly 70 per cent of the population in Uttarakhand is rural, and over 70 per cent of the geographical area falls under forest classification, with 45 to 47 per cent recorded as forest cover. "When people and wildlife share such proximity, negative interactions are bound to occur," explains Pandey. "The reporting of such incidents has also improved, which makes the situation appear more intense."

areas on the fringes of the forest.

However, former Ramnagar block pramukh Sanjay Negi links the rising encounters to expanding safari tourism, arguing that vehicle movement disturbs animals and pushes them towards human settlements. Melkani counters: "In most incidents, the victims were inside forests, often collecting fodder or firewood. These are not cases of animals repeatedly entering houses without provocation. They are encounters that occur when people and wildlife use the same space."

THE SHRINKING HABITAT

Not all experts believe rising wildlife numbers are central to the problem. Traditionally associated with lower-altitude forests and the Terai belt, habitat pressure and broader ecological shifts are forcing tigers to shift upward. Last

"Forest fires and habitat changes have reduced populations of grazing animals as well as smaller prey species. Now the carnivores have little to prey on. Hence, they are pushed to explore new areas, including human settlements"

PETER SMETACEK, *Naturalist and Founder, Butterfly Research Centre, Bhimtal*

To make sense of this surge, one also needs to look at the landscape. Vijay Melkani, forest range officer of the Bhowali Range in Nainital Division, says the rising encounters in parts of Kumaon must be understood in their geographical context. The range, he points out, lies within a larger wildlife landscape that connects Uttarakhand's forest divisions with adjoining habitats, including the Corbett Tiger Reserve and forest corridors extending towards Pilibhit in Uttar Pradesh. As tiger numbers have increased in core reserves, younger or subadult animals often disperse after territorial fights. Such movement, he says, can bring them closer to human-dominated

May, a camera trap photographed a Bengal tiger at nearly 9,875 feet in the Sunderdhunga Glacier Valley in Bageshwar—the first confirmed sighting in the Kumaon Himalayan region. They have also been seen at unusually high altitudes in Askot Musk Deer Sanctuary and Kedarnath Wildlife Sanctuary. Peter Smetacek, naturalist and founder of the Butterfly Research Centre in Bhimtal, argues that rising human density and recurrent forest fires have eroded biodiversity. "Forest fires and habitat changes have reduced populations of grazing animals such as deer, serow and goral, as well as smaller prey species like lizards, rats and birds," he says. "Only species that adapt easily to disturbed environments, such as monkeys and wild pigs, have persisted. Now, the carnivores have little to prey on. When natural prey declines, they are pushed to explore new areas, including human settlements." Even if big cat numbers rise in protected areas, he says, territorial behaviour often forces weaker or displaced animals to move outward.

Dr S. Sathyakumar of the Wildlife Institute of India in Dehradun, who is the coordinating lead author of the *National Human-Wildlife Conflict Mitigation Strategy and Action Plan (2021-26)*, stresses the concept

BIG CAT ATTACKS

DEATHS AND INJURIES FROM TIGERS AND LEOPARDS RISE ACROSS UTTARAKHAND

TIGER POPULATION (2022)



TIGER RESERVES
1. Corbett **260**
2. Rajaji **51**

FOREST DIVISIONS
3. Ramnagar **67**
4. Terai Central **8**
5. Terai East **53**
6. Terai West **52**
7. Nainital **1**
8. Almora **1**
9. Dehradun **3**
10. Champawat **11**
11. Haldwani **36**
12. Lansdowne **29**

